1.1 Colonizing Virginia

Imagine settling in an entirely new place, far across an ocean from your home. How would you prepare for this adventure? The founders of Jamestown, Virginia, found out the hard way just what it was like.

MAIN IDEA Virginia's first colonists struggled with starvation, wars, and disease before finally finding success in their new home.



AMERICAN PLACES

The Chesapeake Bay

The Chesapeake Bay is a large inlet that extends through the present-day states of Virginia and Maryland. It is a rich ecosystem, with more than 150 rivers and streams flowing into it. The area around the bay provided rich farmland to colonists who established farms and plantations there.

FOUNDING JAMESTOWN

In the early 1600s, England began establishing colonies in America. As with Spain and its colonies, England pursued the economic policy of mercantilism, giving it a trade monopoly with its colonies. The colonies provided raw materials to England, where workers made them into goods. Finished goods were then shipped back to the colonies and sold or traded, helping England increase its wealth.

At the same time, merchants and investors developed a new type of business, called a **joint-stock company**. Wealthy individuals invested in a venture, or business project. Their funds paid for the endeavor, and the individuals shared ownership in the venture. This business raised money for exploring trade routes and establishing markets in new locations. In late 1606, a joint-stock company called the **Virginia Company** funded the first English settlement at **Jamestown** in the colony of Virginia. King James I had provided a **charter**, or written grant detailing rights and privileges, to the company to settle the colonies. After a difficult winter voyage across the Atlantic Ocean, more than 100 settlers arrived in the **Chesapeake Bay** and established a fort along the James River.

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The settlers were ill-equipped to establish a colony. They had little experience with farming, hunting, or fishing and were more interested in searching for gold. Soon they were starving. To make matters worse, Jamestown was located in a low-lying area—perfect for mosquitoes that carried malaria, a disease that killed many settlers.

Colonial officer John Smith established a mutually beneficial trade relationship with the Powhatan, a Native American tribe. The Powhatan grew corn that the settlers could use, and the English had goods that the Powhatan wanted, such as weapons. In 1608, Smith became president of the colony and put the settlers to work planting crops, fishing, and building houses. The state of the colony improved.



Pocahontas
Artists have portrayed Pocahontas in various ways, almost always based on information rather than actually seeing her. The top left painting as Lady Rebecca Rolfe in England (1616) is the only known portrait of her from life. Other artists have imagined her as the Powhatan princess who captivated John Rolfe (top right, painting dated 1945), and shortly after her marriage to Rolfe in 1614 (painting dated c. 1852).

Then in September 1609, Smith was injured and returned to England. That same year, the Virginia Company angered Chief Powhatan, who then cut off trade with the settlers. Winter came, and the settlers began to starve again. Any colonist who left the fort risked being attacked. Only 60 colonists survived the winter. In 1614, Chief Powhatan's daughter, Pocahontas, married colonist John Rolfe. The marriage helped usher in peace between the two groups.

SUCCESS AT LAST

In about 1612, Rolfe started to grow a new variety of tobacco in Virginia. He used seeds he had acquired in the West Indies. Rolfe's new tobacco was less bitter than the variety that had been grown in the colony, and by the following year, he began shipping it to England, where it became very popular. Tobacco farmers tried to produce enough to meet rising demand, and tobacco became a driving economic force in the colonies.

In 1619, the Virginia Company tried to persuade English citizens to move to Virginia to build this labor force. Some citizens were freeholders who paid their own transportation and received land in exchange. Others were **indentured servants**, who gave up several years of freedom to have their travel fees paid by the company or another person. Indentured servants were bound for a certain length of time to work to pay off their traveling expenses.

Also in 1619, the Virginia Company established an assembly of elected delegates in Virginia, called the **House of Burgesses**. It became the first representative assembly in the American colonies, and it gave the colonists more local control.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the purpose for establishing an English settlement in Virginia?
2. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** How important do you think John Smith was to the settlers? Use evidence from the reading to support your opinion.
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did John Rolfe's marriage to Pocahontas bring about peace between the Powhatan and the colonists?

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